

BEFORE

After the atrocities and humiliations of World War I, nationalist right-wing ideals took hold in many European countries.

ACTION FRANÇAISE

Founded in France in 1898, *Action Française* was an extreme **right-wing movement** led by Charles Maurras; his political vision included the reestablishment of the French monarchy. The group distributed a daily bulletin of the same name.



CHARLES MAURRAS

THE GERMAN IDEAL
In the 19th century, the concept of an eternal, ideal German *Volk* (people) and *Volksgeist* (spirit of the nation) began to emerge. The philosopher **George Hegel** spoke of the German spirit as the “**spirit of the new world**” and Friedrich Nietzsche envisioned a “master morality” in which strength triumphs over weakness, unrestricted by the “tyranny” of virtue. These concepts appealed to Hitler, who twisted them to suit his own purposes.

THE PAN-GERMAN PARTY

Georg Schönerer founded the Pan-German Party in the 1880s in Austria. Its aim was to **unite all German-speaking peoples** under German rule. The Party had a presence in the Austrian Parliament, but Schönerer’s violent racism, which had led to his imprisonment for assaults on Jews, was too extreme for the politics of the day.

ITALIAN NATIONALISTS SEIZE FIUME

In 1919, Italian patriots, led by the poet **Gabriele D’Annunzio**, occupied the Italian-speaking port of Fiume on the Croatian coast. This action, which had popular support in Italy, was born of fury at gaining a mere 9,000 square miles in post-World War I peace settlements.



Fascism

World War I left Europe exhausted. Unemployment was rife as economies struggled to adapt to peacetime conditions. Disillusioned with their existing forms of government, many people were drawn to a new brand of nationalism known as fascism.



National Socialist Party poster

The Nazi Party promised to bring stability and order to Germany after the economic and social upheaval of the 1920s. It appealed to the people’s basic demands, as this election poster from 1932 shows, with its promise of “Work, Freedom, and Bread.”

The emergence of fascism and Nazism in Europe was made possible by a range of conditions. Economic hardship after World War I was a primary factor. In addition, the period 1918–20 was marked by political instability. Violence and lawlessness erupted across much of Eastern Europe, Germany, Italy, and Spain, between communists (see p.335) and their political opponents. Political thinking on the left was fractured, with communist, socialist, and trade union groups often in conflict with each other. On the right of the political spectrum, the nationalist philosophies of fascism began to gain ground. Fascists loathed communism’s internationalist thinking and had no faith in democratic government. Many, including Hitler and Mussolini, were veterans of World War I (see pp.372–75) and resented the old ruling elites who had led them into

a disastrous war. With no attachment to church or monarchy, fascists put all their faith in love of their nation, favoring a strong, ordered state.

The massive human and economic costs of the World War I left Italy’s government undermined. In 1920, bands of “Blackshirts”—adopting the Roman symbol of the *fascis* (see right), which represented their belief in collective strength and authority over individual freedom—began to take the law into their own hands, attacking

FASCISM A radical nationalist ideology. Fascists believe in strong, authoritarian leadership and a collective, classless society bound by racial allegiance.

socialists and striking trade unions. In the absence of government authority, the Fascists were widely seen as the protectors of law and order. In October

Italian coin
“Fascist” comes from the Roman *fascis*—a bundle of sticks (weak on their own but collectively strong) surrounding an ax—a symbol of authority.



1922, Fascist leader Benito Mussolini, ordered his Blackshirts to march on Rome and seize power. King Victor Emmanuel III refused to back his Prime Minister’s request for military support and invited Mussolini to form a new government. In 1926 Mussolini assumed absolute power, dissolving all other political parties and brutally silencing political opponents. Known to his people as “*Il Duce*,” or “the Leader,” Mussolini cultivated an image of himself as Italy’s one true leader, the choice of the masses. In reality, Italy was a police state.